

Weather

Centro Linguistico di Ateneo
Excellence in Linguistic Training

Grammar Focus	Topic Focus
Future forms	Talking about the weather
Question tags	Vocabulary and Phrases

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Talking about the Weather

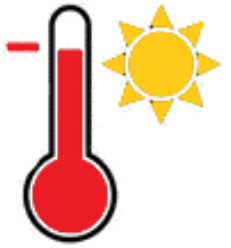
So, what's the weather like in your city today?

We'll be talking about the terms you need to describe sunny days, stormy days, and all those days in between, but before we get into the vocabulary, let's see why the weather is such a **hot topic** with so many people.
Have you ever noticed how people seem to love talking about the weather? Whether they're standing in the supermarket checkout line, or meeting new people at a party, the weather is a popular **conversation starter**; even at more formal occasions, like business meetings, it is a standard topic to make **small talk**.
This might be because the weather is often changeable from day to day and from place to place, making it a relevant subject for everyone.
To fully participate in these conversations, you'll need a lot of weather-related English words and phrases in your vocabulary.
Knowing them is also important for your safety! Imagine you're in a local pub and the owner casually tells you, "Be careful of the heavy **fog**, when you enter the motorway." You'll be glad you know what the word **fog** means!

Talking about the Weather - Vocabulary

Hot / Warm

When we say it's **hot**, we refer to **very high temperatures**, such as in the middle of summer, when the heat can get quite **uncomfortable**.
When it's **warm**, temperatures are **fairly high but tolerable**.



- Today is so **hot** that I've been sitting under the shade all day.
- When the weather is **warm**, I prefer to wear light clothing, such as summer dresses.

Cold / Cool

Cold refers to **very low temperatures**, close to **freezing** - the type of weather that requires a **heavy coat** to go outside.
With **cool**, however, we're talking about **fairly low, spring-like temperatures** when you may only need to wear a sweater out.



- Don't forget your coat; it's **cold** outside.
- On **cool** days like today, you should be fine with a light jacket.

Talking about the Weather - Vocabulary

Sunny / Rainy
Sunny weather means there's lots of **sunshine**.
Its opposite is **rainy** weather, which means **lots of rain**.





- On **sunny** days, I like to take the kids to the beach.
- **Rainy** days are the best time to stay home and read a book.

Clear / Cloudy (or overcast)
A **clear** day is bright with no signs of bad weather.
A **cloudy** day, however, means the skies are filled with clouds with little or no sun.





- We're having such **clear** nights, this week! We can see a million stars!
- It looks **cloudy**; you should bring an umbrella in case it rains.

Talking about the Weather - Vocabulary

Dry / Humid



When it's **dry**, there's no rain or moisture in the air.
When it's **humid**, the air is **moist** and contains a large amount of **water vapour**.
Humid weather usually makes us **perspire** (**sweat**) more.



- Bush fires are common around here when the weather is **dry**.
- The weather's been so **humid** lately it's impossible to go outside without **breaking a sweat**.

Foggy / Misty

These two adjectives refer to **hazy conditions** caused by **small droplets of water in the air** that make it difficult to see.
Fog (noun) **forms closer to the ground** and is **thicker** and more difficult to see through.
Mist (noun) usually **forms on hills** and mountains and **isn't as thick**.



- Remember to turn on your headlights when driving through **foggy** areas.
- It's **misty** up in the mountains in the mornings.

Talking about the Weather - Vocabulary

Gusty / **Windy**
These adjectives describe the **wind**.
Gusty suggests a **sudden brief burst of wind**
Windy refers to wind which is blowing stronger than usual.



- It's been **gusty** all afternoon and my umbrella was blown away.
- As we were walking along the beach, it started to get **windy**.



Thunder / **Lightning**
These two nouns are often used **together** when speaking about **storms**.
Thunder is the loud **booming sound** which usually follows a **flash of lightning** in the sky.



- Whenever there's **thunder** and **lightning**, my terrified cat crawls under the bed.



Talking about the Weather - Vocabulary

Stormy
This is the adjective that describes a day when there is a **storm**, heavy rain that falls with strong winds, thunder and lightning.



- The **storm** was so strong, it caused a blackout for a few hours.
- On **stormy** days I like to look at the lightning that flashes in the sky.

Hail
Hailstones are pieces of ice that fall from the sky. They can be quite big and do a lot of damage.

- The **hailstones** were so big, they ruined all the grapes in the vineyard.
- My car got **hailed** on, but luckily my insurance paid for the damage!



Talking about the Weather - Vocabulary

Snowy

This is the adjective that describes a day when **snow** falls, usually abundantly, covering everything in white **snowflakes**.

- It was a **snowy** day, so we stayed home.
- When they saw how **snowy** it was, the children ran out to make a **snowman**.





Drizzle

This is a light rain.

- It was just **drizzling** when we left the office, so we didn't need an umbrella.



Talking about the Weather - Vocabulary



Hurricane
A storm with a violent wind, in particular a tropical cyclone in the Caribbean.
❖ **Hurricane** Katrina destroyed New Orleans in 2005.



Tornado
A tornado is a violently rotating column of air that is in contact with both the surface of the Earth and a thundercloud.
❖ The windstorm called **Tornado** is often referred to as a twister, whirlwind or cyclone.

Flood
This is a condition when it rains so heavily, that the soil is unable to absorb the water, which rises and submerges roads and houses. Furthermore, rivers can overflow and flood the land around them.
❖ It was raining so hard, that the river broke its levees (argini) and **flooded** the whole city.



Questions and Phrases to talk about the Weather

To say that the weather is **good**, you can answer:
It's warm and sunny.
There's nothing but blue skies outside. (*i.e. good weather*)
We couldn't ask for better weather!
Here the use of the comparative adjective **better** suggests that the weather is so good that it couldn't get any better.

You could use other comparative adjectives like **nicer** or **more beautiful**.
We couldn't ask for nicer weather this week!

This is the best weather we've had all [season/week/year]!
The superlative adjective **best** is used to show that this weather is simply the best and nothing else can be better. Here's another example:
This is the most beautiful weather we've had all week!
Delightful weather, isn't it?

Questions and Phrases to talk about the Weather

To say that the weather is **bad**, you can answer:
This is the worst weather we've had all spring!
Awful weather, isn't it?
Using the question form can be quite charming, especially when you expect the person to agree with you.

You could use similar adjectives like **nasty** or **terrible** instead.
Nasty weather today, isn't it?
It's boiling hot!
The word **boiling** is used here as an adjective, not as a verb, to create an image of how hot it is.
You could also use adverbs like **extremely** or **really**.

It's freezing outside! ***It's pouring outside!*** ***It's sizzling outside!***
In this simple sentence, you may use any verb in its -ing form to describe the weather such as **pouring** (*raining very heavily*) or **sizzling** (*very hot*).

Questions and Phrases to talk about the Weather

I can't believe this [weather]!
Here's a simple way to express your surprise. Feel free to use any other suitable noun such as **storm** or **wind**.

It's raining cats and dogs!
This is a popular idiom (expression) for saying that it's raining heavily.

It looks like [rain].
Here you're saying it looks like it might **rain in the near future**. It could be that you can see dark clouds or hear thunder.

You could use other nouns like **snow** or a **storm**.
[A storm] seems to be [coming/heading] this way.

The phrase seems to be suggesting that a storm is likely to be coming. You could also say:
Heavy rain seems to be heading this way.

Questions and Phrases to talk about the Weather

What's the temperature like (out there)?
This question is asking about degrees in Fahrenheit or Celsius.

However, people are typically looking for an approximate temperature:
It's around 40°.

Of course, an answer like the following is still acceptable:
It's really (hot/cold/warm/cool).

What's the weather forecast?
If you're planning a trip or event, you might want to know the weather ahead of time.
Forecast simply refers to what kind of weather is expected in the coming days or weeks.

The next few days should be simply gorgeous (extremely beautiful)!
We will have horrible weather, unfortunately.

Questions and Phrases to talk about the Weather

The weather will be warming up soon.
Warming up means the temperatures will be rising and it's **getting warmer**.

The opposite of warming up is **cooling down**:
The weather will be cooling down soon.

It's expected to be [hotter] than last year.
The phrase **expected to be** suggests that you think it'll happen.
Use a **comparative adjective** here to compare the weather now with another time in the past. You could use other comparative adjectives like **colder** or **less windy**.

Remember:
do NOT say "There is the sun", but "It's sunny".
do NOT say "There is the wind", but "It's windy".
do NOT say "There is the fog", but "It's foggy".